

MEDIAN

Vo.5.0 PHILOSOPHICAL SPECIFICATION

Sanctuary Made Systemic

CORE VERSION THESIS

Away creates the need for sanctuary. Dwell makes sanctuary functional. EMBODY makes sanctuary felt.

PURPOSE

A design-philosophy handoff for the main MEDIAN design thread that will assemble the structured v0.5.0 revision. This document defines the version boundary, governing principles, canon relationships, and acceptance criteria. It is to be read alongside the Home Loop Rework, Embodiment Register, and Ecological Influences specifications.

Document Version 1.0 • Target Revision: MEDIAN 0.5.0

1. Executive Handoff

This document does not replace the three companion specifications. It tells the revision author how to understand them together. The central task of v0.5.0 is not to append several attractive features to the prior game. It is to reorganize MEDIAN around a clarified dramatic and mechanical proposition: the colony is a home whose successful operation creates the conditions in which small lives can be fully lived.

Version decision

The change from 0.4.x to 0.5.0 is warranted because the work alters the simulation scale of Home Mode, the register architecture, the role of equilibrium, the species spatial grammar, and the positive dramaturgical destination of play. It is not a balance pass.

1.1 Required companion documents

Companion specification	Primary contribution to v0.5.0
Home Loop Rework (DWELL)	Places-Practices-Roles, global colony capacities, Citizen-Days, Readiness, quiet equilibrium, Role shortfall, and Home Encounter transaction.
Embodiment Register (EMBODY)	The Fifth Register; globally available within a stable Home; Practice and Presence experiences; Campaign Memory integration.
Ecological Influences	Real-world behavioral inspiration for Mouse, Rabbit, and Squirrel; species-relative topology; privileged-camera and cutaway doctrine.
This Philosophical Specification	Version thesis, architecture-level synthesis, non-negotiable principles, anti-goals, and instructions for building the formal 0.5.0 revision.

1.2 Revision-author mandate

The structured 0.5.0 revision should treat the principles in this document as its governing layer. Where a lower-level mechanic conflicts with the philosophical specification, the mechanic must be revised or explicitly identified as an unresolved contradiction. The revision should not merely paste together the companion documents; it should integrate them into one coherent game architecture.

- Preserve mechanisms that make the colony logically achievable, readable, and satisfying to operate.
- Preserve emotional goals only where the mechanics create genuine mental and temporal space for them.
- Preserve species identity through spatial relationships and bodily logic, not cosmetic differentiation alone.
- Preserve the distinction between colony-scale and citizen-scale crunch.
- State uncertainties honestly; do not canonize ecological or production claims merely because they are evocative.

2. Why This Is v0.5.0

Version 0.5.0 marks the point at which MEDIAN's Home half ceases to be a supporting base-building layer and becomes one of the project's defining original systems. The redesign is architectural in five separate ways.

Simulation subject

Home Mode now treats the Colony as the quantitative subject, while Away Mode treats the Citizen as the quantitative subject.

Economic model

Dwell moves away from standalone production buildings and interchangeable worker optimization toward collective capacities, civic Roles, inhabited Places, and contextual Practices.

Dramatic pressure

Role shortfall becomes exposure to situated trouble rather than constant damage-over-time or mandatory maintenance clicking.

Register architecture

MEET becomes a universal situational-choice register, and EMBODY becomes a newly recognized fifth register available within Home.

Species foundation

JOIN, GATHER, and CONNECT gain ecological, perceptual, and bodily foundations that influence building, movement, risk, encounter manifestation, and sanctuary.

VERSION BOUNDARY

v0.5.0 is not “more Home content.” It is a new answer to what Home Mode is for.

3. Core Philosophical Thesis

MEDIAN is a game about the creation, endangerment, and experience of sanctuary. The highway median is not merely a hostile tactical map. It is a place where fragile lives build local order inside a world whose scale and indifference are overwhelming. The player’s responsibility is not endless emergency response. It is to establish, protect, and periodically restore the conditions under which ordinary life can occur.

HOME DOCTRINE

The player’s task is not to prevent perpetual collapse. It is to establish and periodically restore the conditions under which ordinary life can occur.

3.1 The successful resting state

A well-run colony must be capable of coasting. Routine needs can be covered. Ordinary upkeep can be handled. Reserves can be adequate. No current Project or crisis need demand immediate attention. This state is not a failure of pacing. It is the achieved plateau on which the game’s sentimental and observational ambitions become possible.

- Stable is a broad plateau, not a knife-edge optimization target.
- Flourishing represents surplus capacity and chosen ambition, not merely survival above zero.
- Strain should arise from disturbance, absence, expansion, or deliberate risk—not from an arbitrary universal decay treadmill.
- The interface must grant the player permission to linger without the colony deteriorating in real time.

3.2 Emotional design follows logical satisfaction

Players will not care about a Webisode, a quiet citizen gesture, or the beauty of a court while they remain preoccupied with unexplained deficits and cascading failure. The game must first satisfy the player’s need to understand that the colony works. Only then can attention open toward the lives inside it.

EMOTIONAL CAUSALITY

*Understand the colony → make sound decisions → achieve stability → gain mental breathing room
→ notice the inhabitants.*

4. Two Scales of Crunch

The redesign depends on a strict but complementary distinction between the quantitative subjects of Home and Away. Named citizens remain present in both modes, but they are resolved at different scales.

Dimension	Home / DWELL	Away / TRAVEL-RISK-MEET
Crunch subject	The Colony	The Citizen
Primary question	How much of the community is committed to each responsibility?	Which particular citizen can endure, solve, or survive this situation?
Contribution	One citizen supplies one apportioned share of Role capacity.	Stats, gear, conditions, relationships, and individual abilities resolve distinctly.
Growth	Places, Practices, Roles, reserves, structure, population, and collective capability.	Experience, wounds, distinctions, gear, and individual advancement.
Risk	The colony becomes thin, overextended, or exposed.	A particular citizen is hazarded, harmed, rewarded, or lost.
Identity	Occupancy, continuity, association, memory, and current civic duty.	Capability, personal history, temperament, progression, and consequences.

4.1 Home Roles are civic responsibilities

A Home Role is not a character class and should not generally be modified by personal aptitude. Twig is not 1.2 Gardeners while Bramble is 0.8. The assignment means that a named citizen has devoted one share of the colony's finite attention to gardening. This preserves low-population opportunity cost without turning Dwell into a personnel-ranking puzzle.

SCALE DOCTRINE

At Home, a citizen is an individually accounted-for unit of commitment. Away, a citizen is an individually resolved unit of capability.

4.2 Individuality without productivity ratings

- The player sees which named citizens currently inhabit each Role and Practice Place.
- A citizen's absence on Expedition removes that exact share of colony capacity.
- Repeated occupancy creates narrative association: Twig's garden, Sedge's watchpost, Bramble's favored overlook.
- Campaign Memory and EMBODY reveal habits, friendships, tensions, and embodied preferences without converting them into efficiency coefficients.
- Wounds, incapacity, absence, and death affect Home through availability, not hidden productivity multipliers.

5. DWELL: The Colony as an Inhabited System

Dwell is macro-stewardship of an inhabitant collective. It is not a conventional RTS production grid softened with sentimental art. The colony is organized through Places, Practices, and Roles, and its capacities are resolved globally because the Colony—not the individual worker—is the relevant simulation subject.

Term	Philosophical meaning
Place	A physically situated part of the settlement that can be inhabited, remembered, damaged, improved, and related to other Places.
Practice	A recurring way the community lives and works in a Place. Practice is not merely output; it is sustained civic behavior.
Role	A current share of responsibility held by a named citizen. Roles express colony posture, not permanent profession.
Project	A deliberate undertaking that consumes Citizen-Days and temporarily redirects ordinary capacity toward change or repair.
Condition	A compact global statement of collective state—such as structural soundness, stores, cohesion, or readiness—rather than a swarm of per-object meters.

5.1 Global abstraction is a virtue

A global Structural Condition can stand for hundreds of small diegetic realities: loosened lashings, damp insulation, blocked drainage, shifted stones, routine patching, and accumulated weathering. The abstraction is correct because maintenance is a colony posture. It becomes dramatically specific only when circumstances justify opening it through MEET.

ABSTRACTION DOCTRINE

Persistent capacities remain global. Acute consequences become situated.

5.2 Citizen-Days and comprehensible effort

Citizen-Days provide a low-population unit of work. They make construction and repair legible without requiring worker-path micromanagement. One citizen working for two days and two citizens working for one day are meaningfully equivalent at the Home scale. The player-facing language should emphasize Projects rather than factory-like queues.

5.3 Sufficiency, margin, and equilibrium

Role capacities should answer whether the colony's ordinary responsibilities are covered. Additional capacity may accelerate Projects, create redundancy, or improve response options, but the core success condition is sufficiency. Once ordinary load is met, the player is not required to keep feeding labor into an infinite percentage race.

- Adequate Builders keep normal structural wear handled.
- Adequate Caretakers keep ordinary household and store burdens attended.
- Adequate Watchkeepers keep normal warning and interpretation coverage in place.
- Additional capacity represents readiness, ambition, or redundancy—not relief from unavoidable daily punishment.

6. Species Spatial Identity

The three Core species are not alternate stat packages. They possess different bodily definitions of safe, intelligible, and inhabitable space. Their placement verbs must remain visible in the uninhabited shape of a settlement.

Species	Verb	Settlement image	Bodily foundation	Civilizational promise
Mouse	JOIN	Manor House	Continuous enclosure, edge contact, tactile legibility.	There is room for you under our roof.
Rabbit	GATHER	Court / Cul-de-Sac	Shared surface space held near concealment and escape.	We will make another neighborhood for you.
Squirrel	CONNECT	Web	Reachability, elevated anchors, alternate routes, distributed refuge.	We will bring you into reach.

6.1 Ecology informs; civilization transforms

Real-world ecology is an influence layer, not canon. It helps identify what each species' body reads as safety. MEDIAN's civilizations then elaborate those instincts into rooms, courts, bridges, civic Practices, memorials, and political life. Ecological claims should be used only where their applicability is clear, and imaginative elaboration should be labeled as such.

TRANSLATION RULE

Ecology determines what safety feels like. Culture determines what civilization builds from it.

6.2 Visual legibility outranks literal concealment

Colony Mode must expose rooms, citizens, facing relationships, and route logic for satisfying play. The camera therefore possesses privileged transparency. Mouse fourth walls and roof planes may be omitted; Rabbit concealment canopy may be thinned; Squirrel foliage may be suppressed. These omissions are non-diegetic.

REPRESENTATIONAL DOCTRINE

Open to the player is not open to the world.

7. Role Shortfall and the Dramatic Economy of MEET

The most distinctive Home-system achievement of v0.5.0 is the conversion of deficiency into situated drama. A shortfall should not necessarily deduct points every Dawn. It means the colony is failing to quietly prevent a category of trouble. MEET is the register through which that latent exposure becomes a concrete circumstance and a consequential choice.

7.1 Hidden weakness logic

The Home specification proposes a hidden ledger of Role support. Contextually relevant deficiencies are ranked. Aggregate deficiency governs the cadence or likelihood of shortage-driven Colony Encounters; the largest relevant weakness determines the primary stake, and the second determines complication or collateral exposure.

- Not every Role is relevant to every situation.
- Demand is contextual; an unlocked but currently unnecessary Role should not count as deficient merely because it is empty.
- A deficiency should not be charged simultaneously through constant damage, increased event frequency, worse event severity, and mandatory repair unless a major circumstance clearly warrants all layers.
- Frequency must saturate and allow recovery windows so the system does not recreate an entropy treadmill.

7.2 Universal Encounter Register

MEET is invoked whenever the player must answer a bounded circumstance, at Home or Away. A colony can meet heavy winds, floodwater, a threatened collapse, illness, a dispute, or a stranger. The visual paradigm is a staged situational tableau with constrained consequential choices—not necessarily two opposing entities.

Source register	Examples of what is met
DWELL	Heavy winds, structural exposure, flood, illness, food contamination, household dispute, human maintenance activity.
TRAVEL	A stranger, resource opportunity, blocked route, predator sign, discovered artifact, territorial request.

Source register	Examples of what is met
RISK aftermath	A stranded companion, collision consequence, changed traffic condition, immediate rescue decision.

7.3 The three-choice transaction

The Register should usually present a compressed moral and strategic triangle rather than a broad tactical command bar.

1. Spend one resource or capacity to protect the primary threatened value.
2. Spend a different resource or capacity to protect or redirect another value.
3. Spend neither and accept the compounded consequence.

Strong Roles elsewhere in the colony should usually alter costs, warning, or consequence previews rather than adding a new button for every possible contribution.

ENCOUNTER ECONOMY

Save this, save that, or preserve both resources and suffer more.

8. The Five-Register Architecture

v0.5.0 recognizes five distinct player relationships to the world. They are not a simple linear sequence. MEET is cross-cutting; EMBODY is Home-only; the others define primary spatial and control states.

Register	Verb	Availability	Core subject	Player relationship
Colony	DWELL	Home	Collective life	Arrange, sustain, and understand the colony.
Field	TRAVEL	Away	Distance and environment	Carry life through extended territory.
Crossing	RISK	Away	Immediate spatial danger	Preserve life inside high-speed hazard.
Encounter	MEET	Home or Away	Bounded circumstance	Choose how to answer a situation.
Embodiment	EMBODY	Home only	Lived animal scale	Participate in or accompany ordinary embodied life.

8.1 Dramaturgical cycle

The registers together express a cycle rather than a ladder of intensity.

DRAMATURGICAL CYCLE

Danger makes sanctuary necessary. Dwell makes sanctuary functional. EMBODY makes sanctuary felt. Campaign Memory makes sanctuary personal.

8.2 Exposure and Tharn

Exposure is the accumulating burden of danger, distance, uncertainty, and prolonged alertness. It naturally ebbs in a secure, functioning colony. Tharn is not merely high Exposure; it is an acute categorical break requiring protection, care, and time. EMBODY may portray the ebb of Exposure or a stage of recovery, but it is not a trauma-clearing minigame and must not casually erase Tharn.

9. EMBODY: The Positive Destination of Home

EMBODY is a globally available Register within Home whenever the colony has achieved Quiet Equilibrium and the selected citizen is present and available. It is not unlocked separately by each citizen's Role margin. The colony, as a whole, has made time and safety for embodied life.

9.1 Two forms

Form	Player relation	Examples
Practice	Participate in a bounded animal-scale activity already contained within ordinary colony life.	Run a squirrel bridge, knock raspberries into sacks, carry stores through a Mouse wing, bound through a Rabbit court.
Presence	Accompany or witness a citizen through repose, play, tenderness, tension release, or sensory grace.	Watch the river with Bramble, listen to rain from a Mouse hearth, bask in a Rabbit court, settle at a Squirrel junction.

9.2 Guided experience, not free roam

EMBODY should favor authored, bounded experiences with a beginning, sensory focus, small change, and natural release. Direct control may be light or kinetic, but the mode should not become a general traversal sandbox, collectible hunt, or second optimization game. A squirrel bridge run is safe exhilaration, not a punitive platforming challenge.

9.3 No exclusive economic advantage

Participating in EMBODY must not become mandatory optimization. A berry-gathering activity can represent work already adjudicated by Dwell; it should not yield a superior harvest unavailable to players who skip it. EMBODY gives access to lived meaning, not a hidden production multiplier.

9.4 Campaign Memory absorbs the Webisode function

The original Webisode concept supplied brevity, character exposure, named relationships, and procedural campaign memory. v0.5.0 should preserve those strengths but fold them into EMBODY and a broader Campaign Memory layer. Prose may initiate, accompany, or record an embodied moment, but no separate “Register 4.5” is needed.

10. Ecological and Perceptual Grounding

The Ecological Influences specification should be used as a disciplined source of design prompts rather than a zoological canon. Its greatest value is the recognition that the same median is functionally three maps because each species reads different topology.

Human feature	Mouse reading	Rabbit reading	Squirrel reading
Guardrail	Covered base edge, wall, chamber support.	Screen, brush anchor, partial shelter.	Low chain of climbable anchors.
Culvert	Highway, flood hazard, winter refuge.	Emergency shelter or escape mouth.	Low fallback route.
Sound wall	Continuous edge and cavity source.	Protective boundary that can also trap.	Vertical plane and high anchor line.
Bramble	Covered micro-run and seed trap.	Primary shelter matrix and court envelope.	Low secondary route and material source.
Utility line	Unreachable ceiling or signal.	Overhead exposure cue.	Regional sky-bridge.

10.1 Canonical bodily questions

PERCEPTUAL GEOMETRY

Mouse asks: “What can I remain in contact with?” Rabbit asks: “How quickly can I disappear?” Squirrel asks: “What can I reach from here?”

10.2 Concept-art application

The concept art remains primarily a gameplay and sourcebook communication system. It should not be redesigned into literal zoological concealment at the expense of visibility. Ecology may sharpen implied spatial relationships and encounter vulnerabilities; it must not obscure Places, citizens, room functions, shared courts, or connection networks that the player needs to see.

11. Explicit Anti-Goals

The 0.5.0 revision should actively test proposed systems against the following failure modes.

Anti-goal	Why it conflicts with v0.5.0
Perpetual entropy combat	If stability is impossible, the player never gains the attention required to inhabit the colony emotionally.
Home aptitude ranking	Turns named citizens into optimized worker coefficients and muddies the Home/Away simulation split.
Every Place as a factory	Recreates RTS production logic beneath warmer terminology.
Idle citizens must always output	Instrumentalizes ordinary life and makes repose look like wasted production.
Every shortfall causes daily damage	Creates maintenance leakage rather than memorable situated consequences.

Anti-goal	Why it conflicts with v0.5.0
Encounter option sprawl	Dilutes the moral and strategic clarity of MEET into a tactical menu.
EMBODY as mandatory buff routine	Converts sanctuary, play, and recovery into an optimization chore.
Ecology as literalist canon	Flattens civilization into animal behavior and can undermine gameplay readability.
Visual realism over operational clarity	Hides the colony the player is meant to understand, build, and care about.
Production-scope veto on concept design	The sourcebook standard is compelling, coherent, and technically plausible design—not immediate studio staffing feasibility.

12. Required Structure of the 0.5.0 Revision

The main design thread should build a structured revision document that clearly separates philosophical canon, system canon, supporting models, and open questions. The following order is recommended.

I. Version Thesis and Scope

State why 0.5.0 exists, what prior assumptions it supersedes, and which previous systems remain compatible.

II. Register Architecture

Define DWELL, TRAVEL, RISK, MEET, and EMBODY; identify transitions and cross-cutting invocation.

III. Home/Away Simulation Split

Specify Colony-scale and Citizen-scale crunch, including assignment, absence, growth, and risk.

IV. DWELL System

Places, Practices, Roles, Projects, Citizen-Days, Conditions, Readiness, Dawn adjudication, seasonal systems, and Quiet Equilibrium.

V. Species Spatial Grammars

JOIN, GATHER, CONNECT; placement rules; load and readiness implications; concept-art representation.

VI. Role Deficiency and Colony Encounters

Ledger logic, contextual relevance, cadence, Big/Small Weakness manifestation, three-choice transaction, aftermath.

VII. EMBODY and Campaign Memory

Global Home gate, Practice/Presence forms, experience families, Exposure relation, memory persistence.

VIII. Ecological Influence Layer

Applicable real-world takeaways, uncertainties, species-relative topology, acoustic and edge effects.

IX. Progression and Content Economy

How the colony grows, how citizens grow, what Expeditions bring Home, and what Home cannot generate autonomously.

X. Open Questions and Prototype Targets

Identify undecided formulas, thresholds, exact Role roster, encounter director weighting, and content requirements without pretending closure.

12.1 Canon hierarchy

Where documents differ, the structured revision should apply this hierarchy unless the main design thread explicitly decides otherwise:

1. The latest explicit user decision or correction in the development record.
2. This philosophical specification for architecture-level intent.
3. The three companion specifications for their respective modules.
4. Earlier 0.4.x materials that remain compatible.
5. Research or speculative notes, treated as inspiration unless promoted into canon.

13. Questions the Revision Must Preserve as Questions

Several matters are conceptually framed but not yet numerically or procedurally settled. The 0.5.0 revision should identify them cleanly rather than smuggling provisional answers into canon.

- Does aggregate Role deficiency directly set Colony Encounter frequency, or does world pressure set cadence while deficiency controls escalation and manifestation? The hybrid formulation is promising but not final.
- What exact global Conditions are tracked, and which are visible versus hidden? Structural Condition, Stores, Cohesion, and Readiness are candidates, not yet a complete locked set.
- What is the final Core Role roster, and which Roles are universal, tier-gated, contextual, or species-inflected?
- How are contextual Role demands calculated so that advanced colonies are not punished merely for unlocking additional responsibilities?
- How much of the Big/Small Weakness ranking is visible to the player, and how is causality communicated without making future Encounters fully predictable?
- What exact threshold defines Quiet Equilibrium for EMBODY access?
- How much player control belongs in Practice versus Presence experiences, and what terminology will replace the temporary internal names if needed?
- How does Campaign Memory select which moments persist, avoiding formulaic log spam?
- How does the colony survive at Home without autonomously generating all meaningful advancement, preserving the need for Expeditions?

14. Acceptance Criteria for the Structured v0.5.0 Revision

A successful revision should be able to answer each of the following without contradiction.

- ☐ Can a sensibly built colony reach a stable state that does not require constant intervention?
- ☐ Can the player understand why assigning or removing one citizen matters at Home without consulting personal productivity coefficients?
- ☐ Can a named citizen feel distinctive in Dwell without becoming an optimized worker class?
- ☐ Can Role deficiency matter mechanically without inflicting repetitive daily leakage?
- ☐ Can MEET dramatize both Home and Away situations through the same clear choice grammar?
- ☐ Can JOIN, GATHER, and CONNECT be recognized from settlement form alone?
- ☐ Can ecology sharpen species fantasy without overriding the game's visible colony architecture?
- ☐ Can EMBODY be entered because the colony is safe, not because a citizen needs a mandatory recovery chore?
- ☐ Can quiet days contain meaningful play even when no stat increases?
- ☐ Can Expeditions create a comprehensible domestic sacrifice and return meaningful advancement to Home?
- ☐ Can the player explain why the colony matters beyond its role as an Away-mode resource generator?

FINAL TEST

A revision that cannot make quiet mechanically credible cannot make quiet emotionally meaningful.

15. Compact Doctrine for the Main Design Thread

The following statements are intended as a final quick-reference page for the author assembling the structured revision.

Doctrine	Canonical statement
Version	0.5.0 is an architectural revision, not a late 0.4.x patch.
Home	The Colony is the crunch subject. Citizens contribute equal, named shares of commitment.
Away	The Citizen is the crunch subject. Individual capabilities, hazards, and advancement resolve distinctly.
Equilibrium	Competent Dwell can produce real stability. Successful stillness is a reward state.
Deficiency	Shortfall creates exposure to trouble; it need not cause constant damage.
MEET	All bounded situational choices—Home or Away—use the Encounter Register.

Doctrine	Canonical statement
Species	Mouse JOINS, Rabbit GATHERs, Squirrel CONNECTs because their bodies understand safety differently.
Camera	Open to the player is not open to the world.
EMBODY	Globally available in a stable Home; guided Practice and Presence make sanctuary felt.
Memory	Campaign Memory preserves selected experience; it is not a separate half-register.
Ecology	Influence, not canon; use where applicable and label extrapolation honestly.
Sourcebook standard	Seek solid, compelling, dramaturgically supported, heartfelt, and technically plausible design. Do not allow immediate production staffing to veto the concept.

V0.5.0 CLOSING PROPOSITION

The other registers explain how small lives are sustained and endangered. EMBODY explains why sustaining them is worth doing.